CSIS | KOREA DAILY BRIEF

Thursday, November 5, 2026 No. 225 11 min read

TODAY AT A GLANCE

1. North Korea tested a new air-defense missile system and conducted a cruise missile airport-strike drill, its fourth weapons test in a week.
2. Democrats swept the US midterms, winning both chambers, complicating prospects for a Trump-Kim summit and Seoul's nuclear submarine plans.
3. South Korea approved expanding the Cheonghae anti-piracy unit's operational zone from the Gulf of Aden south toward Oman, adding a P-8A and EOD team.

KOSPI	USD/KRW	BRENT	LEE APPROVAL	KIM LAST SEEN	BOK RATE
5,383.80	1,343.88	$96.50	39%	Oct 30	3.00%
−5.3%	+0.1%	+2.0%	flat Oct 27-29	6 days ago	Oct 2026

01 | TOP STORIES

NK News / Korea Times / Reuters, DPRK

North Korea tests new air-defense missile, conducts cruise missile airport-strike drill

Kim Jong Un's Missile Administration tested a new surface-to-air missile system on Wednesday, confirming its "intelligent multiple guided mode" and target-identification capability, while separately staging a long-range strategic cruise missile strike drill simulating an attack on an enemy airport using cluster munitions on a runway. NK News found that images published by KCNA were heavily doctored. The dual tests mark North Korea's fourth weapons test in a week, following short-range ballistic missile launches from the Sondok area of South Hamgyong Province on November 4.

Yonhap News Agency, US-Korea

Seoul expands Cheonghae anti-piracy mission toward Hormuz, adds P-8A and EOD team

The decision requires National Assembly consent under South Korean law on overseas military deployment. The move follows months of US requests for support in the region after the US-Iran war erupted in February, which Seoul had effectively declined.

Bloomberg, ROK Economy

South Korea's September current account surplus hits record on chip boom

South Korea recorded a *$61.5 billion* current account surplus in September 2026, breaking the prior monthly record of $49.7 billion set in June, the Bank of Korea reported. The year-to-date cumulative surplus through September reached $340.7 billion, more than four times the same period in 2025.

02 | OVERNIGHT

Korea Times, US-Korea

Democratic Congress could complicate ROK nuclear submarine plans and Trump-Kim summit prospects

Experts cited by Yonhap warn Democratic control complicates nuclear-sub transfer and summit prospects.

Dong-A Ilbo, ROK Politics

Seoul High Court upholds Yoon's election law conviction, 18-month suspended sentence intact

Court found Yoon's false statements violated voters' right to informed choice; PPP may owe 39.7 billion won in campaign reimbursements if sentence is finalized.

The Washington Post, DPRK

North Korea launches missiles while rejecting US Binance hack accusation

Pyongyang fired multiple missiles toward the East Sea as Kim Yo Jong branded the FBI's $6.3B Binance attribution a continuation of Washington's hostile policy.

CNBC, ROK Economy

South Korean defense stocks plunge from 52-week peaks as drone era reshapes buyers' priorities

Combined market cap of Hanwha Aerospace, LIG D&A, Hyundai Rotem, and Korea Aerospace fell to roughly 62 trillion won from a 52-week peak of 170 trillion won by end-October.

Bloomberg, ROK Economy

Korea to introduce cornerstone lockups to curb post-IPO selloffs

Seoul plans cornerstone investor lockup rules to stabilize share prices after listings.

The Korea Times, US-Korea

Seoul rejects Moscow's claim that US-ROK exercises rehearse nuclear preemptive strikes

Seoul's Foreign Ministry said the exercises are defensive, annual, and aimed at maintaining combined readiness against North Korea's nuclear and missile threats.

Korea Times, ROK Economy

Seoul court rejects Coupang bid to block 423 billion won data breach fine

The Seoul Administrative Court upheld the Personal Information Protection Commission's fine, the largest ever imposed on a single company, over a breach affecting more than 37 million users.

03 | PYONGYANG WATCH

Kim Jong Un

No public appearance today, last seen 6 days ago

No KCNA watch flag. 7 provocations logged in the last 7 days.

TOP KCNA ARTICLES

NK News / KCNA, DPRK state media

North Korea: US talks remain an option, but Binance accusation demonstrates hostile policy

KCNA carried Kim Yo Jong's statement saying dialogue with the US is an option but not a necessity for North Korea's national interests, framing the FBI's Binance hack attribution as evidence of unchanged US hostile policy.

SENIOR OFFICIALS

Kim Yo Jong, Director, General Affairs Department, Workers' Party of Korea

Kim Yo Jong issued a statement saying US-DPRK dialogue is an option but not a necessity, branded the FBI's Binance hack attribution as 'an extension of Washington's unchanged hostile policy,' and said there is 'no need to sit down with untrustworthy and hostile people' absent a policy change.

Kim Song Nam, International Secretary, Workers' Party of Korea Central Committee

Kim Song Nam led a WPK delegation to Beijing, meeting China's Wang Yi and separately receiving a delegation from the Party School of the Chinese Communist Party Central Committee.

Bottom line: State media confirmed North Korea's fourth weapons test in a week, a new air-defense SAM and a cruise missile airport-strike drill, while Kim Yo Jong publicly conditioned any US talks on abandonment of hostile policy, and the WPK international secretary met Wang Yi in Beijing.

04 ROK GOVERNMENT

President and ministries, Thursday, November 5, 2026

MINISTRY OF FOREIGN AFFAIRS

Deputy Minister Jung Eui-hye

MOFA hosts UK parliamentary delegation; discusses Korean Peninsula, Hormuz, UK-Korea FTA

Deputy Minister for Foreign Affairs **Jung Eui-hye** met a six-member UK parliamentary delegation led by MP Alicia Kearns on November 5, covering the Korean Peninsula, Ukraine, the Strait of Hormuz, and UK-Korea FTA upgrade. UK MPs called for a quick UK-Korea FTA improvement agreement signing and expressed support for Korean soldiers injured in a DMZ landmine blast.

Primary **Foreign Ministry**
Reported **Newsis**

MINISTRY OF FOREIGN AFFAIRS

Director-General for Latin America Choi Jun-ho

MOFA director visits Venezuela; discusses energy, critical minerals, and infrastructure cooperation

Director-General **Choi Jun-ho** met Venezuela's first deputy foreign minister and hydrocarbon ministry deputy minister in Caracas on November 4-5, following up a Foreign Minister phone call in August. The meetings focused on energy, core minerals, infrastructure, and Korean corporate participation in Venezuela's reconstruction.

Primary **Foreign Ministry**

MINISTRY OF UNIFICATION

Unification Ministry

MOU to hold inter-Korean peace and unification culture event in Gyeongju on November 7

The Unification Ministry will hold the third 'Peace On:dam' peace and unification cultural project of the year at Cheomseongdae in Gyeongju on November 7, featuring a new 'peace guide Kkukku' character and a pop-up event at KTX Gyeongju station November 2-6.

Primary **Unification Ministry**

PRESIDENTIAL OFFICE

President Lee Jae-myung

President inspects Jangwi District 9 public redevelopment site in Seoul, orders supply acceleration

President **Lee Jae-myung** visited a public redevelopment project in Seongbuk District on November 4 and ordered faster housing supply, instructing officials to allow conversion of private redevelopment projects to public ones and to strengthen incentives including floor area ratio for early-stage districts.

goodtimes.or.kr

NATIONAL ASSEMBLY

Democrats table 'fabricated indictment special prosecutor bill'; PPP launches filibuster

National Assembly Plenary

The ruling Democratic Party brought the '조작기소 특검법' (fabricated indictment special prosecutor bill) to the National Assembly floor; the People Power Party responded with a filibuster, blocking a vote.

05 | US-KOREA TRADE & INVESTMENT

TARIFF STATUS

Autos and parts Section 232	**15%** Reduced
Steel and aluminum Section 232	**50%** Active
Reciprocal tariff 10% surcharge (Section 122), expired Jul 24 2026	**Expired**
Section 301 USTR, Section 301 determination, pending, no fixed date	**Active**

6 more sector rates on the trade reference page; no rate changed since the last issue.

Steel and aluminum remain at 50% and automobiles at 15%, both under Section 232. The Section 122 surcharge expired July 24, so there is no baseline reciprocal tariff in force. Section 301 investigations launched March 11 against 16 trading partners including South Korea are now the primary prospective tariff vehicle.

INVESTMENT PLEDGE, $350B

$350B pledged; 1 project selected so far, led by Encinal gas-fired power plant, Texas ($22.3B).

$150B shipbuilding, $200B strategic sectors, $100B energy purchases; no official Strategic Investment Corporation drawdown figure reported to date.

06 | CAPITOL HILL

Chosun Ilbo, Senate, Statement

Pro-Korea Senator Jon Ossoff re-elected in Georgia

Senator **Jon Ossoff** secured re-election in Georgia, keeping a pro-Korea voice in the Senate; Ossoff has been a vocal advocate on Korean Peninsula policy and Korea-related trade issues.

07 | KOREA AND THE WORLD

DW, Multilateral, Multilateral

North Korea tells EU to 'mind its own business' on human rights resolution

Pyongyang rejected a European Union human rights resolution targeting North Korea, telling the EU to 'mind its own business,' as South Korea simultaneously joined the UN General Assembly resolution as co-sponsor for the fifth consecutive year.

Reuters, Middle East, Diplomacy

South Korea to expand anti-piracy operations closer to Strait of Hormuz

Seoul approved expanding the Cheonghae unit's zone from the Gulf of Aden to waters south of Oman, adding a P-8A maritime patrol aircraft and an explosive ordnance disposal team, subject to National Assembly approval.

08 BUSINESS & ECONOMY

WSJ

South Korea October inflation remained above Bank of Korea target

South Korea's consumer price inflation stayed above the Bank of Korea's target in October, the Wall Street Journal reported, maintaining pressure on the central bank ahead of its next rate decision.

09 UPCOMING

NOV 6

BOK Governor departs for BIS Governors' meeting

Bank of Korea Governor Shin Hyun-song departs November 6 for the Bank for International Settlements governors' meeting, running November 6-11.

NOV 7

Unification Ministry peace culture event, Gyeongju

MOU holds 'Peace On:dam' inter-Korean cultural outreach event at Cheomseongdae, Gyeongju, running 11 a.m. to 5 p.m.

NOV 18

APEC Leaders' Summit, Shenzhen

The 33rd APEC Leaders' Summit is scheduled for November 18-19 in Shenzhen, China, with BYD selected as official partner; the summit is relevant to South Korea-China and regional trade diplomacy.

JAN 26

Seoul High Court verdict: Yoon insurrection appeal

The Seoul High Court set January 26, 2027 as the sentencing date for former President Yoon Suk Yeol's insurrection appeal; special counsel had sought the death penalty.

10 ANALYSIS

OFFICIALS ON X

MND Spokesperson (@MNDSpokesperson), Primary, November 5

“Today the Cheonghae unit's extended deployment motion passed the vice-ministerial meeting. Due to the US-Iran war and Houthi clashes since early this year, coalition forces have concentrated in the Gulf and Red Sea, leaving the Gulf of Aden under-protected; Somali piracy has surged more than three times over the previous year. The Ministry of National Defense has decided to expand the Cheonghae unit's deployed forces and operational area to restore freedom of navigation on international sea lanes and protect Korean nationals and economic interests.”

The motion requires National Assembly consent before deployment; the full Yonhap report confirms the operational radius will roughly double to approximately 1,930 kilometers. **View on X**

Commander UNC/CFC/USFK (@CDRUNCCFCUSFK), November 5

“Eighth Army honored ROK Army Staff Sgt. Nam Wun Soo, a Korean War hero of the Battle of White Horse Hill, at a ceremony.”

Gen. Xavier Brunson's repost of the Eighth Army ceremony marks a Korean War commemoration at a time when North Korea has conducted four missile or weapons tests in one week. **View on X**

Unification Minister Chung Dong-young (@coreacdy), November 5

“Looking at Kim Yo Jong's statements over the past month, more than ten appearances, the subtext is that if it serves their interests, the possibility of dialogue remains open. She has used the word 'dialogue' for the first time, and I read this as a signal that the door is not entirely closed.”

Unification Minister Chung's assessment tracks with today's Dong-a Ilbo coverage of Kim Yo Jong's November 4 statement conditioning talks on abandonment of US hostile policy. **View on X**

Direct posts by tracked official accounts, attributed as posted. Not independently verified beyond the post.

STATEMENTS

Kim Yo Jong

"Dialogue is clearly one of the options, but it does not necessarily serve our national interests."

The statement came the same day North Korea fired multiple missiles and one day after the US midterm results showed Democratic gains that experts say complicate Trump's summit push. **Source**

COMMENTARY

Kyiv's warnings of tens of thousands more North Korean troops never came true. The Lowy Interpreter argues that Ukrainian warnings of massive North Korean troop deployments proved overstated, with Pyongyang extracting what it needed from the Russia partnership at smaller scale. The piece contends North Korea's primary benefits, combat experience, hard currency, and weapons technology, have already been obtained. This analysis is relevant to the CSIS Korea Chair's ongoing NK-Russia Axis research. (lowyinstitute.org)

Democratic gains unlikely to derail Korea-US investment deal. The Korea Herald editorial argues that Democratic control of Congress will not fundamentally disrupt the Korea-US strategic investment deal. The piece cites bipartisan consensus on shipbuilding, semiconductors, and power infrastructure as sectors insulated from partisan reversal. KOTRA's post-midterm analysis, cited in Korean-language sources, reached the same conclusion. (The Korea Herald)

11 | PUBLIC SENTIMENT

Lee approval

39%

0 pts vs Oct 13-15
Gallup Korea
October 27-29, 2026

Trend: Down from 42% on Aug 25-27, across 7 readings.

Ruling	Opposition	Independents
Democratic	People Power	
35%	30%	28%

12 | THE WIRE

ROK POLITICS

Yonhap

Appeals court schedules Yoon insurrection verdict for January 26

The Seoul High Court set January 26 as the sentencing date for former President Yoon Suk Yeol's insurrection appeal; special counsel sought the death penalty while Yoon reiterated in his final statement that the December 3, 2024 martial law declaration did not constitute insurrection.

DPRK

NK News

Brazil's first ambassador to North Korea in a decade takes post in Pyongyang

Brazilian Ambassador **Ricardo Primo Portugal** paid a courtesy call on the Chinese ambassador in Pyongyang, confirming he had taken up the post after a decade-long vacancy, according to a Chinese Embassy announcement.

NK News

UNESCO evaluation body recommends North Korean taekwondo as standalone intangible heritage

A UNESCO evaluation body recommended inscribing taekwondo as intangible cultural heritage representing the DPRK under a Pyongyang nomination titled "Taekwon-Do, Traditional Martial Art in the Democratic People's Republic of Korea," ahead of a final committee decision next month, without South Korean involvement.

ArmsControlWonk

Nampho Port container yard very likely expanding by at least 45%, ArmsControlWonk finds

ArmsControlWonk analysis of October 30 imagery shows Nampho Port is very likely increasing its primary intermodal container storage yard surface area by at least 45%, which the analysis flags as atypical since North Korea does not generally transport goods domestically in standard intermodal containers.

38 North

38 North: North Korea soft-revealed new stealth strategic UAV at October 30 exhibition

38 North analysis of the 'unmanned aeronautical technology development-2026' exhibition documents a first public showing of a new North Korean stealth strategic unmanned aerial vehicle, following Kim Jong Un's call for absolute superiority in drone technology at the same event.

13 | SATELLITE & LOCATION WATCH

Elevated or alert, 2 of 11 sites: Yongbyon Nuclear Complex; Sohae Satellite Launch Station.

ACTIVITY, RISING

Sinuiju-Dandong (NK-China border)

38 North satellite imagery from October 16 confirms trucks traversing the New Yalu River (DPRK-Friendship) Bridge one day after the October 15 official opening, marking the start of commercial vehicle traffic. Daily NK reports (Oct 31) that North Korean trucks have still not joined Chinese cargo trucks on the bridge two weeks after the Oct 15 opening; North Korean transport officials are still preparing vehicles. North Korea-China trade reached $299M in September 2026, the second-highest monthly total in 2026. Kim Jong Un crossed the New Yalu River Bridge on October 24 during his unannounced visit to Dandong. Daily NK reports on Nov 3, 2026 that North Korea is courting Chinese investors to build hotels and shopping complexes in Sinuiju, with officials pitching lodging and commercial projects following the revival of Chinese interest after the New Yalu River Bridge opening and Kim's October visit to Dandong. ArmsControlWonk analysis (Oct 30 2026) finds Nampho Port's primary intermodal container storage yard is very likely expanding by at least 45%.

imagery as of 2026-11-05

10 other monitored sites: no new reporting since the last issue.

That's today's brief. No. 225

TOMORROW

BOK Governor departs for BIS Governors' meeting

Feedback and tips are welcome. Write to **alim@csis.org**.

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